construction sites. The single largest source of this migration was Kerala and, as already discussed in Chapter 5, many of these workers were descendants of Arabs who had come to India in the Middle Ages to trade. By the 1990s, large Indian communities would come to agglomerate in hubs like Dubai.

Thus far, Indian migrations had been predominantly of blue-collar workers and of traders. From the late sixties, a new kind of emigration took shape: that of middle-class Indians in search of education and white-collar opportunities. By this time, India's socialist economic model was beginning to fray and the optimism of the early years of independence was fading. What began as a trickle became a flood by the late 1980s, and it was commonplace for middle-class Indian students to take the SAT and GMAT tests and apply to foreign universities. The United States was the biggest recipient of this flow, although smaller streams also went to Britain, Canada and so on. By the late '90s, yet another sub-category emerged—Indian professionals who were hired into the global economy. This group clustered around important cities like Singapore, London, New York and Dubai, and were concentrated in sectors such as medicine, law, finance and information technology.

Over the years, many of these groups have mixed and merged, but traces of each stream can still be discerned in the early twenty-first century. What is interesting is the extent to which 'Indianness' has been consciously retained by most of these expatriate communities even when they have been away from the subcontinent for generations. I remember two gentlemen, both Swedish citizens, whom I met on a boat trip from Dar-e-Salaam to Zanzibar in May 2010. Their ancestors were Gujarati Muslims who had settled in Zanzibar in the late nineteenth century but were forced out by race riots in the mid-1960s. They were on a trip back to rediscover their roots. I found them in the cabin chatting away in Kutchhi and, when they discovered I was Indian, they insisted that I share their supplies of Gujarati snacks. They had never visited India, but I was amazed by how strongly Indian they felt. Indeed, they were very proud of India's recent economic successes and were planning a trip to see their ancestral homeland.